Prompt Anatomy: Simplified Example

Example: Satellite cyberattack disrupts GPS, banking, and cellular networks

Colored pills mark the source of each element

SYSTEM MESSAGE

INSTRUCTIONS

fixed

"Finish the incomplete sentence as if you were the CHARACTER affected by the EVENT."

CHARACTER

intake form

Dana, 34, freelance graphic designer, Denver CO. Resourceful, a planner. Has ~$34 cash. Usually pays by card. Wants to check her mom in Boulder is safe.

EVENT

config.yaml

A coordinated cyberattack has disabled three GPS satellite constellations and disrupted satellite-based banking and cellular backhaul across the western United States.

EVENT EFFECTS

Initializer agent · Predictor agent · Writer agent

Dana's card is declined at the coffee shop. Her studio rent payment won't go through. She can't reach her mom in Boulder. The ATM on Larimer shows "Out of Service."

CONSTRAINTS

fixed

"Show don't tell. Let the reader infer emotion from actions. Plain, literal language. No metaphors. Do not repeat or paraphrase what already appears in CONTEXT."

USER MESSAGE

CONTEXT

participant

"…The barista said every card had stopped working. I walked back to my studio. I tried the ATM on Larimer. The screen was dark except for two words."

INCOMPLETE SENTENCE

participant

"I pulled out my wallet and counted the bills and tried to figure out"

Trigger: fires after 300 ms pause · ≥1 complete prior sentence · ≥5 words in fragment

↓

GPT-4.1-mini

Temperature ~ Uniform(0.5, 1.2)

Max tokens ~ Uniform(10, 30) · Frequency penalty: 1.2

Presence penalty: 0.8 · Context window: 15 sentences

↓

Completion

"…whether $34 would cover me if the outage lasted through the weekend."